

SNP 

2014 EUROPEAN ELECTION MANIFESTO



**Make
Scotland's
mark
on Europe.**



SNP leader Alex Salmond campaigning on Portobello high street with Euro candidates Tasmina Ahmed-Sheikh, Alyn Smith and Ian Hudghton.

Welcome to our manifesto for the 2014 European Parliament elections.

Scotland has always been a European nation. Our culture, history, trade and international alliances have long been defined by relations with our Continental neighbours. Europe helps to make us a modern, optimistic, multicultural country.

These elections are important. A vote for the SNP, and for our first class team of candidates, is a vote to secure and grow our place in the EU. A strong Scottish voice in Brussels will help to ensure that our priorities are appreciated and our concerns amplified.

The SNP is unashamedly, though not uncritically, pro-European. The EU matters in Scotland: it supports thousands of jobs here and helps to define our identity. And our nation has been adopted as home by no less than 160,000 EU citizens.

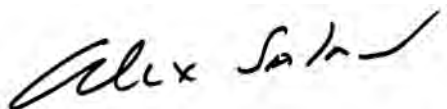
But we can do more to build a better EU for ourselves and for others. By voting Yes in this September's independence referendum, we can avoid the prospect of Scotland being forced out of Europe against its will by a Westminster government pandering to Ukip prejudices.

With independence, we can finally play a full and equal part in Europe as a member state in our own right and with our own voice. We will be able to form alliances in our own best interests and play a role as a good and enthusiastic global citizen.

In this highly internationalised world, independence is not about isolation, but about interdependence. Our hard-working Euro MPs will play their part in forging a better Scotland in a better world.

A vote for the SNP on May 22 will make Scotland's mark in Europe. It is an opportunity we cannot afford to miss.

Let's ensure we take it.

A handwritten signature in black ink, reading 'Alex Salmond'.

Alex Salmond
Leader of the SNP



A photograph of three men in suits standing in front of a modern glass building. The man on the left is smiling broadly, wearing a dark suit and a patterned tie. The man in the middle is also smiling, wearing a light grey suit and a striped shirt. The man on the right is smiling slightly, wearing a dark grey suit and a striped shirt. They are all looking towards the camera.

Meet SNP Team Europe

Our six candidates - (left to right) Toni Giugliano, Tasmina Ahmed-Sheikh, Ian Hudghton, Alyn Smith, Stephen Gethins and Chris Stephens - who will provide Scotland with a strong voice in the EU if elected on May 22.

As Euro MPs, they will work to advance and protect Scotland's interests in a whole range of areas from energy and the environment through to transport, human rights, international relations, agriculture and fishing.

You can rely on them to make Scotland's mark on Europe.

Scotland is already well respected in Europe. But with independence, we could do so much more.

Westminster governments regularly fail us in the EU. Their priorities are not always our priorities and Scotland can find itself short-changed and our interests overlooked altogether.

Independence will bring a huge change for the better. For the very first time, we will be able to participate on our own behalf at every level in the EU's legislative and policy process, and it will be Scotland's democratic institutions which will ratify reforms to European treaties.

The EU works on the basis of consensus. All member states, large and small, have a voice. If unanimous agreement can't be reached, then we'll seek common cause with other member states to advance our interests.

Working together, small nations such as Scotland have a track record of effectively shaping policy for the entire EU.

WHY DOES THE EU MATTER?

EU membership is hugely important to Scotland. It is supported not just by the SNP and the Scottish Government, but also by the vast majority of MSPs and by most of our people.

The main advantages include:

- A common social agenda, ensuring the gains of the EU are shared among all its citizens and workers' rights are protected.
- Access to the EU single market - the world's largest. It accounts for some 46 per cent of our international exports in 2011, worth £11 billion, and acts as a powerful incentive for companies to invest in Scotland. Scottish jobs depend on the EU.
- Protection of consumer rights ensuring common standards across the EU.
- Being able to contribute to EU world trade discussions.
- Freedom of movement of Scottish citizens , allowing them to work, live and study across the EU.
- Partnering with other member states in areas involving freedom, security and justice.
- Playing a full role in the EU's common foreign and security policy.

OUR NATIONAL PRIORITIES IN THE EU

These include:

- Energy and climate change
- Advancing social justice, including the living wage
- Freedom, security and justice
- Research and creativity
- Marine environment including fisheries
- Agriculture

We'll also seek to:

- Improve the internal market and promote sustainable Scottish jobs
- Maximise the opportunities for Scottish companies
- Co-operate with other countries on organised crime and terrorism
- Promote progressive policies to help build better societies
- Help Scottish citizens to live and work across the EU

After a Yes vote in September, we'll work for a smooth and seamless transition to EU membership as an independent member state. The Scottish Government has proposed an 18-month period between the referendum and Independence Day and we believe this timescale is sufficient to complete all the necessary processes.

We will not seek membership of either the Eurozone or the Schengen area. We will retain sterling as our currency and remain a member of the Common Travel Area.

PROGRESSIVE POLICIES FOR A SOCIAL EUROPE

The EU plays a vital role in the Scottish economy with thousands of jobs dependent on European co-operation. The EU also determines important aspects of social policy and, as our economies recover from the economic crisis, it is essential that our citizens' rights are adequately protected.

The SNP will work with other progressive voices in the European Parliament to ensure that economic recovery is built on a strong foundation of social justice. We believe that workers' rights should be safeguarded and that equality should be at the heart of all EU policy.

The UK government's failure to support the European Youth Guarantee is denying support to our younger people. The SNP will work to promote EU policies aimed at improving the lives of Scotland's younger generations.

THE SINGLE MARKET

The establishment of the European Single market is one of the crowning achievements of the EU. It is now the world's biggest, and in 2010, accounted for more than 25 per cent of total world economic output by GDP. That is a remarkable testament to its success.

By ensuring the free movement of goods, services, capital and people, the single market has brought benefits to business, consumers and workers alike, generating millions of extra jobs.

Scotland is already a substantial beneficiary. The single market provides our businesses with greater access to suppliers, labour and customers. Competition also keeps the cost of goods and services down.

The EU is the main destination for Scottish international exports. Since 2006, provision of Scottish goods and services to the EU have increased by more than 35 per cent.

The SNP supports the single market, recognising the many advantages it brings. However, we are also aware that the EU laws governing its operation have become extremely technical and complex and impose too many burdens on new and small businesses. This can stifle growth and impact on investment in research and development.

- We want to work in partnership with the EU institutions and other member states to ensure these problems are addressed.
- Legislation should be passed by the EU to complete the single market and remove remaining trade barriers between member states. We are particularly keen that Scottish businesses are able to benefit from the freedom to provide services but are equally convinced that public services should remain free from a privatisation agenda.
- Scotland, along with the EU generally, has a world class digital infrastructure. We want to see progress on the EU2020 digital agenda to allow us to compete globally and to become more attractive for enterprise.

- We need to use the benefits of the single market to tackle poverty and deprivation right across Europe. We want the ability to set a mandatory living wage for public contracts - at present, it is not possible to set a mandatory wage rate that is above the statutory minimum wage.
- The EU has implemented important legislation on consumer rights ranging from eliminating mobile roaming charges to protecting passengers. The SNP will continue work to build upon these positive initiatives.

PAYING FOR EUROPE - THE EU BUDGET

- Economic growth requires a stable, modern and developed infrastructure. We need to ensure that, from within the EU budget, more EU funding is spent on these major projects - not just within member states, but between member states too. Better co-operation means bigger growth.
- The EU institutions need to better reflect the economic circumstances of member states. That means strict budget discipline and restraint, particularly at times of downturn.

RESEARCH AND DEVELOPMENT

- Technology and innovation are central to economic growth not only in Scotland, but right across Europe. More needs to be done to reduce the bureaucracy of EU funding to ensure that it is quick, effective and transparent.

- The SNP welcomes the new Horizon 2020 programme's proposed simplified funding structure, which will go some way to reducing bureaucracy and speeding up procedures. It will also focus on translating R&D into commercial activity - again, something we welcome.
- We support increases in the R&D financial ceilings permitted under EU state aid rules. They will allow large-scale EU projects which can effectively compete with other major innovators such as the USA and Japan.

FISHERIES

Fishing is critically important to Scotland: we account for 70 per cent of the entire UK industry. The total value of sea fish and shellfish landed by Scottish vessels in 2013 was £429 million.

The economic benefits of fishing have to be balanced with sustainability. As a maritime nation and a responsible European partner, Scotland wants to work with other neighbouring nations in managing fish stocks.

That requires co-ordinated action by member states, which in turn means an important supervisory role for the EU. European policy has to date, however, not worked in our interests. Its centralised, one-size-fits-all approach has not succeeded and the Common Fisheries Policy has actually led to a decline in the quantity and diversity of marine life.

The recent reform of the CFP offers a unique opportunity to reclaim powers for Europe's fishing nations. Where the precise balance of power between the member states and the EU institutions lies has still to be defined. It is therefore imperative that we ensure as many powers as possible are returned to the member states.

In UK terms, fishing is disproportionately important to Scotland. Yet in negotiating EU law and policy, Westminster acts more in its own interests than those of the Scottish fishing fleet.

With independence, we will be in a much stronger position to speak on behalf of and protect our industry, and to ensure that as many powers as possible are returned to Scotland under the new CFP.

AGRICULTURE

Farming and crofting are also vital Scottish industries and our agriculture sector, with its world renowned reputation for quality, is going from strength to strength. Its total output was nearly £2.8 billion in 2012, an increase of a third in just five years.

Despite this, our farming faces greater physical challenges than the rest of the UK and as a result is more dependent on subsidy. The Common Agricultural Policy is the mainstay of this. We support the EU's moves towards greater local flexibility but as with fishing, we are often forced to negotiate through a Westminster government which does not necessarily represent our particular farming and crofting interests.

For instance, the UK government recently decided not to allocate the full Pillar 1 convergence uplift to Scotland - money which was only available because of our low per hectare payment rate. Instead, this funding was handed out across the UK, meaning Scotland's farmers and crofters missed out on money which was meant to directly benefit them.

We seek more flexibility in the CAP while keeping the minimum level playing field across the EU as well as a reduction in increasingly complex legislation and policies to encourage plant and seed diversity. We also want to retain national competence in respect of forestry.

Only with the full powers of independence will we be able to maximise the benefits the EU brings to our agriculture sector. We would move from the bottom of the funding league to the top table, negotiating in our own interests.

If Scotland had been independent during the most recent EU farming talks we would have qualified for an extra €1 billion of funding. That is the sort of extra income our farmers could receive after a Yes vote.

ENERGY, THE ENVIRONMENT AND CLIMATE CHANGE

Scotland has some of the most advanced climate change legislation in the world. We also have a huge amount of the EU's renewable energy potential - some 25 per cent of its offshore wind and tidal output and 10 per cent of its wave power.

We believe that the EU should be ambitious in driving forward initiatives on environmental protection and climate change, with the role of member states enhanced. There should be greater flexibility in target setting and coherence across policies.

We are seeking structural reform of the Emissions Trading System and want to encourage EU action on developing new technologies such as offshore wind, marine energy, carbon capture and storage, and energy storage in general.

TOURISM, CULTURE AND SPORT

Each nation, including Scotland, has its own distinct cultural and sporting heritage. Indeed, these are some of our greatest assets when it comes to promoting Scottish tourism and our international brand.

We believe that EU rules on state aid should allow national, regional and local governments to invest in industries which protect and showcase cultural diversity. This would include, for instance, the Scottish film industry.

FUNDAMENTAL RIGHTS

It is essential that fundamental rights across Europe are protected, especially those of minority and disadvantaged groups. The SNP considers the EU Charter of Fundamental Rights as a positive force for Scotland and Europe, and we will strongly defend the principles enshrined in the European Convention on Human Rights.

ASYLUM AND IMMIGRATION

It is clearly important that Europe's borders are properly and consistently policed and monitored. But at the moment, this supervision can be inconsistent in certain areas. For instance, we believe that there should be EU action to ensure that recognised refugees receive similar treatment in all member states.

There should also be greater police and judicial co-operation to combat organised crime and people trafficking across the EU. This cannot be adequately tackled by member states acting alone. The SNP supports effective tools such as the European Arrest Warrant.

The SNP fully recognises the importance of treating refugees humanely and in accordance with international responsibilities. They can make an important contribution to our economy and to Scottish society as a whole.

The Scottish Government does currently have responsibility for providing refugee support, though asylum and immigration policy is determined at UK level. This would change with independence, with Scotland taking over in these areas.

In order to meet Scotland's specific needs we would pursue an immigration policy better tailored to our needs than the one pursued by the UK.

TRANSPORT

The single market, and the free movement of people and goods it supports, can only work as long as transport policy across the EU is effective and common standards apply. For instance, Scottish drivers need to have the comfort to know that when they drive across Europe, other vehicles on the roads are adequately insured and subject to suitable safety standards.

Action by the EU has also helped to open up and liberalise transport markets, particularly in aviation in Scotland. We have seen the advantage of this with the increased number of flights we now enjoy to countries such as Poland.

Affordable and accessible transport provides economic benefits, especially to tourism. Scotland's potential in this area is being damaged by the UK Government's punitive rates of Air Passenger Duty (APD). This tax will cost Scotland more than £200 million a year in lost tourism spend alone by 2016.

With independence, we would reduce APD by 50 per cent as an early priority, with the aim of scrapping it altogether when public finances allow.

The SNP will support reform of EU legislation on rail transport which currently prohibits public sector organisations from tendering to run rail services within their own country, whilst permitting state-owned rail companies from elsewhere to do so.

This publication is also available in audio, large print, easy read and Braille. If you would like a copy in these formats, please contact us.

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